

## How Change Shaped My Future

My name is Saber. I was born in the governorate of Taiz, Yemen where I lived most of my life. I grew up with my family in a small village. Life was peaceful, and I felt happy being close to people I loved. But in 2014, a war started in Yemen between different political groups. Many people lost their homes, jobs, and even family. My parents didn't feel safe anymore, so we made the hard choice to leave. First, we went to Jordan, and then we came to the United States. This journey changed my life.

In Jordan, everything felt new. The streets were busy, and people spoke Arabic in a different way than I was used to. At first, I felt confused and a little lost. But then I met kids from places like Syria and Palestine. We talked, played at night in the street, and shared stories. They helped me feel like I belonged. I learned that I could make friends and feel okay, even in a new place.

But coming to the U.S. was the hardest part. I didn't speak English. In class, I was the only Arabic speaker. I felt lost in class and couldn't talk to anyone. At home, things were also difficult. We didn't have our own place, so for the first year, my family lived in a hotel that the IRC provided. My dad was always busy trying to find a job and a home. Many times, I had to help. If he had to go somewhere, I would speak for him. I made phone calls, went to appointments, and helped translate even when my English wasn't that good yet. That's how I learned faster. I also joined online classes with the IRC on weeknights to practice more.

Then I found something special: "coding". I didn't know what it was at first, but I was curious. I wanted to know how apps and websites worked. The first time I wrote code in Python, it was only a few lines, but it worked and I felt so happy. It felt like magic. Coding gave me something I could control, even when my life was full of change.

In the summer of 2024, I got my first job through the SYEP program. I worked as a teacher assistant for two months. Helping kids learn made me feel proud. I saw how much I had grown from a boy who didn't speak English to someone helping others.

Now, I want to keep going. In college, I want to study software engineering. My dream is to use technology to solve real-world problems, especially for people who had to move, like my family. I want to build tools to help refugees learn skills and connect with others.

My journey from Yemen to Jordan and then to the United States taught me a lot. It wasn't easy to leave my home, but it made me stronger. I've learned that kindness, hard work, and never giving up can help you succeed. Learning English and coding showed me that if I keep trying, I can do anything.